

National University of Computer and Emerging Sciences
Lahore Campus

Engineering Management

Sessional-I Exam

(MG4015)

Date: 24- Sept -2025

Course Instructor(s)

Dr. S. M. Sajid; Haris Kazmi

Total Time (Hrs): 1

Total Marks: 30

Total Questions: 3

Roll No

Section

Student Signature

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Attempt all the questions.

A case study is attached to this question paper and all questions refer to this case study.

CLO # 1: Analyze management principles for engineering

Q1: In the context of the attached case study, **analyze** in what ways and to what extent does this case study reflect issues of personality? How would you deal with this situation if you were the chief executive?

[10 marks]

CLO # 1: Analyze management principles for engineering

Q2: Could John have **calculated** the things differently and reduced the likelihood of this problem arising?

[10 marks]

CLO # 1: Analyze management principles for engineering

Q3: Could **differentiating** between different personality types helped John, or deal more effectively with the crisis?

[10 marks]

John and the Sales administrator

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John was the production manager in a medium-sized manufacturing company in the South East of England. The company produced black plastic rubbish sacks from recycled plastic waste. John was in his late thirties and had been recruited by the chief executive to be the production manager/director designate about one year earlier. His background was that of an industrial engineer and the brief given to him was to increase the productivity of the production unit through modernization, improved planning and control systems, together with better supervision and employee management.

The general atmosphere within the company was one of hostility between management and the work-force at all levels. No one trusted anyone else and disputes were common. Deliveries were invariably late; this was used as a pressure point by supervisors and employees as a way of getting overtime, as and when they wanted it. In return management did not respect the non-management employees and would frequently threaten them with the sack or total closure of the company. When John was brought into the company it was hoped that his professional background and production experience would help to improve matters.

John began by spending most of his time in the factory 'walking the job' and speaking to employees and supervisors as often as possible. The poor performance of the factory was well known by all concerned and everyone would claim to have an interest in sorting it out, but nothing actually changed. A similar state of affairs existed in the administrative offices, where it was not uncommon to find staff saying to customers that it was 'Them in the factory' that were responsible for the late delivery and they were 'Just being awkward as usual'. The sales director was a remote individual and not a well-integrated member of the senior management team, which also consisted of the chief executive, production manager (John) and the finance manager. The sales director had worked for the company the longest and spent most of his time away from the office visiting his favorite customers (current and potential) and supposedly helping to develop new products. His staff had to contact him by phone most of the time if they needed him as he was only in the office about one day each week. Consequently, most of the sales activity was effectively controlled and managed by the sales office manager. John was making slow progress in the factory. New planning methods and supervisor training had been introduced, as well as some of the human resource practices improved. For example, attendance control procedures had been tightened and employees having time off work for any reason were interviewed on their first day back at work. Discussions were underway with the trade union over changes to the terms and conditions of work, but this was only making very slow progress. Some impact was evident on delivery schedules, although not enough to deal with the major problem of delays being used to manufacture the need for overtime.

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One of the key working relationships that existed was between John as the factory manager and Ann, the sales office manager as she was the most common point of contact between customers and the company. The working relationship between these two was particularly important when orders were delayed or changed for any reason. Unfortunately, Ann and John did not get on at either a personal or professional level. Ann considered that the customer was right every time irrespective of the effect on the factory and that the factory had a duty to accept that a customer might change their minds and quietly fit in with her 'demands' on behalf of the customer. These demands were inevitably passed on as instructions over the telephone, even though Ann was junior to John in the hierarchy. This was not John's preferred way of working and if there was a problem from his side of the company, he inevitably went to see Ann to explain what the situation was and to see if some form of compromise could be arranged. This approach was usually brushed aside with comments such as, 'It's your problem, what am I supposed to tell my customer? You have let me down again. You and your factory people are hopeless.' If pushed she would ring the customer to see if alternative delivery times could be agreed, but this was inevitably couched in terms of, 'The factory have let us down again by failing to produce when they should and they want you to compensate by changing delivery times.'

On one occasion, a customer had rung to change an order and Ann rang John to instruct him as to what he should do. John was in the middle of a production meeting and had all the supervisors and production planning staff in his office discussing the next week's activities when the phone rang. He picked it up and heard Ann begin to lay down the law as to what needed to be changed, which he realized would significantly change the plans so carefully worked out for the next week. So he simply said that he was in a meeting and put the phone down. Well slammed it down might be a more accurate description.

Ann was shocked at this disrespect of her and her position as she saw it and immediately rang the sales director to tell him that John had been very rude to her etc. After speaking to him, she immediately went directly to see the chief executive and complained that she was too important to the company to be treated as she had been and that she expected the chief executive to immediately discipline John in order to put him in his place. John was subsequently asked to go and see the chief executive to provide his side of the story.